

5. WRITING FROM STIMULUS MATERIAL

Students are often required to write in response to a variety of materials provided. This section will show you how to produce this kind of writing.

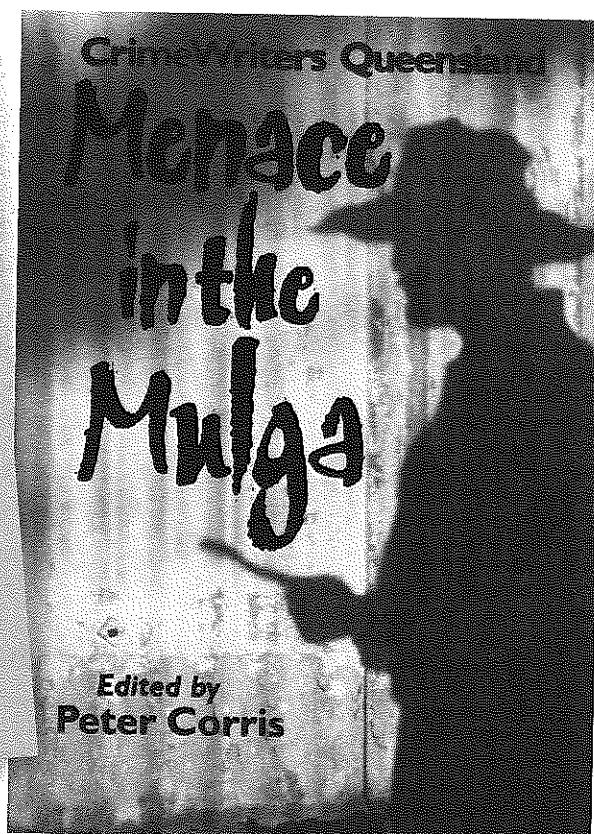
The following four texts are all linked by a common word: **Mulga**.

Mulga is a type of dense scrub vegetation found in the interior of Australia, but it's also a common synonym for the outback.

ACTIVITY:

Study the front and back cover of *Menace in the Mulga* at right.

- Is the book cover an example of imaginative, informative or persuasive writing?
- Imagine that you are in a bookstore at the airport. Give reasons why this cover would or would not attract you.
- Turn the book over. The blurb on the back cover is designed to hook you as well. Analyse the features of language that try to persuade you to purchase this book.



17 new stories of dark deeds with a western drawl

The CrimeWriters Queensland gang rides out west – to a landscape where the potential for bad behaviour is as wide as the brim of a bushie's hat, the humour's as dark as the black stump, and the stings in the tales are sharp as snake bite.

More great reading for a warm arvo on the verandah from eleven of your favourite Sunshine State authors and four intriguing newcomers.

The verdict on CrimeWriters Queensland's previous fiction:

- "... treebark-hard in detail and salty fictionality ..." Graeme Blundell, *The Australian*
- "... there is much to commend in this collection ..." Paul Wilson, *The Courier Mail*
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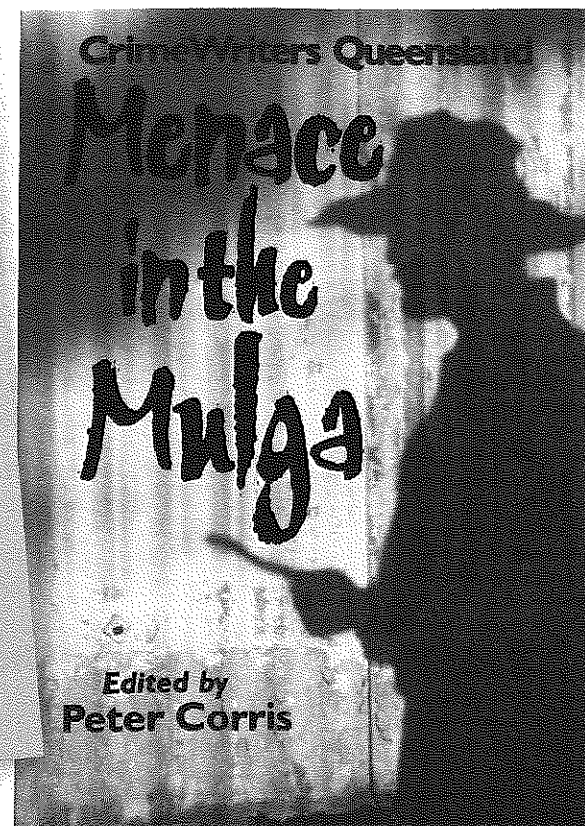
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from *The Croc and the Blue Dreaming*

Joy Loggie

Snake Creek is doing it tough. What part of the bush isn't? I'll do paid work for anyone, anywhere, although that is only one reason why I'm spading out Oscar Smellie's pig pens before breakfast on this warm summer morning.

Jim Beck shovelling pig-shit is the vindictive sod's idea of a payback for a deciding vote against him at the last shire council meeting – that plus the fact he also manages the bank holding my mortgage to ransom.

As soon as the spade slides into the first heap of manure and rotting leaves I spot a familiar long pale 'grub' weaving a slow lethal dance – I freeze.

'I'm not paying you good money to play bloody statues.'

'That's a death-adder – a big bugger.'

The silence behind me is definitely pregnant as I carefully move into a killing position.

'Leave the freaking thing alone – pack it in and go home.'

I'm aggrieved enough and broke enough to take my eyes off the adder's deadly lure. 'What did I do?'

Oscar's staring at the beckoning tail-tip as if mesmerised. 'Nothing – nothing absolutely nothing. Come back in an hour and you can give Porter a hand with the west fence. Now, piss off.'

This is odd. I'd have sworn Oscar felt too dirty on Dave to put paying work his way. Thanks to the long drought and his position in the bank, Oscar usually gets whatever whatever he wants in Snake Creek. The notable exception has been Blue Dreaming, a large sapphire Dave mined south of Anakie in the 1940s.

The pale blue gemstone is so finely cut and polished that underwater colours of a tropical reef can be glimpsed in the translucent azure depths.

Oscar's fancy 'bit-on-the-side' lusts for the Blue Dreaming but Dave refuses to be bullied into parting with the rare gem dreaming in a grubby pouch hanging from a leather cord around his scrawny neck.

Dave is my neighbour and a mate. He lives alone on the only property in Snake Creek not in hock to the bank. Barely fifty kilos dripping wet, he believes seventy-eight is too young to retire so he runs chooks and goats and takes on casual work.

ACTIVITY:

Read the following extracts from the beginning of two of the stories in *Menace in the Mulga*.



- a. Give 3 reasons why the narrator is spading out Oscar Smellie's pig pens.
- b. Explain the only reason why Oscar Smellie is providing work for Dave Porter.
- c. What is:
 - The 'Blue Dreaming'?
 - Oscar's fancy 'bit-on-the-side'?
- d. Because 'The Croc and the Blue Dreaming' is imaginative writing, the author has used figurative language – simile and metaphor – in her story. Look at the descriptions of the snake and the sapphire for example. Identify the figures of speech and what they emphasise about these two symbols or features of the outback.
- e. After reading the beginning of the story, try to predict how it might develop. Write a plot outline in a few sentences. Remember to use some figurative language in your own imaginative writing.

from **Roo Kill**

Garrett Russell

'Forget the roos, you're the mongrels we should be shootin' first!'

I swung away from the American on the stage and focused my camera on the woman who had yelled out from the floor. She was being cheered by the rest of the crowd in the old timber hall. I could feel the excitement vibrating from the journalist hovering over my left shoulder. Edwin T Allison had the story of his career here, if only he could figure out how to translate bush Australian for American television.

'We give you a swag and tucker, show you country overrun by mobs in their thousands, and you still have the cheek to call them endangered.'

The woman sat down to wild applause. I swung away from the sun-beaten faces and faded work shirts back to the stage. The American stood towards the front at the microphone. Behind him sat a strangely mismatched set: a grazier, a roo shooter and another environmentalist.

'You're right, I have seen some kangaroo,' the American said evenly. 'And it's true our government regards them as endangered. My mission is to be neutral on the subject until I have completed my firsthand report. And Mr and Mrs Cooper,' he looked straight at the woman in the audience, then turned briefly to the grazier behind him. 'I want to thank you publicly for the hospitality you have shown me and my party. It's the best time I've ever enjoyed staying with folks who'd rather shoot me.'

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- a. Who is the narrator in this story?
- b. Note this story's strong opening. Explain why it gets the reader's attention. Who is the speaker and who is being addressed? Why is the speaker so angry?
- c. Explain Edward T Allison's mission.
- d. 'We give you a swag and tucker, show you country overrun by mobs in their thousands, and you still have the cheek to call them endangered'. Explain this sentence in the context of the story and its purpose.
- e. 'I want to thank you publicly for the hospitality you have shown me and my party. It's the best time I've ever had staying with folks who'd rather shoot me.' What does this sentence show about Edward T Allison? Why is it an effective ending to the first section of the story?

ACTIVITY:

Both of these stories are about the outback but they explore different issues with different characters, in contrasting writing styles. Decide which extract is more effective as a comment on the outback and as fiction. Write a paragraph justifying your choice.